

Apocalypse, But Make It a Subscription

The Rhetorical Incoherence of the Teen Manhattan Project

EXISTENTIAL RISK.
NOW WITH RECURRING BILLING.

Subject:
Critical Socio-Technical
Analysis / Satirical Theory

Date:
December 2025

TODAY'S MENU of DISASTERS

 **NUCLEAR SUNDAE™**
Global cooling. Local regret. \$19.99 /mo

 **PLAGUE PASS™**
Premium pathogens. Always fresh. \$14.99 /mo

 **AI TAKEOVER™**
Alignment? LOL. We'll see. \$24.99 /mo

 **CLIMATE CHAOS™**
Extreme weather, on demand. \$12.99 /mo

 **MEMORY MELTDOWN™**
Infinite memory. Infinite problems. \$9.99 /mo

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Rare. Unpredictable. Devastating. \$29.99 /mo

BUNDLE & SAVE THE WORLD!

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AVAILABLE ON ALL MAJOR PLATFORMS

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Appocalypse
Store

GET IT ON
Doom Play

★★★★★ 4.5 ★, 1.2B DOWNLOADS

RESTRICTED
TECHNOLOGY
BEYOND THIS POINT



...SOLD HERE!

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Project Analogy
(Literal Enforcement)



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Tier of Destiny

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RECURRING
BILLING
BECAUSE
THE END ISN'T
ONE-TIME.

CANCEL ANYTIME
*IF ANYTHING
IS LEFT.

APOCALYPSE
IS COOL!

SAM

TIPS
APPRECIATED.
SO IS
AMNESIA.

NEW!
ICBM
POP
EXTRA
CRUNCH!

UPGRADE TO
APOCALYPSE
PRO
UNLOCK TOTALITY™

BRINGING EXISTENTIAL RISK
TO A SCREEN NEAR YOU!

Abstract

This paper examines a novel institutional paradox in contemporary artificial intelligence discourse: the simultaneous framing of AI as (a) a civilization-defining, potentially catastrophic technology comparable to the Manhattan Project, and (b) a consumer subscription product actively marketed toward teenagers.

We argue that these positions are logically incompatible. Through analysis of public rhetoric surrounding "infinite memory" and "inevitable AGI," we identify a phenomenon we term *Catastrophic Casualization*: the domestication of existential-risk language in service of standard growth incentives.

We conclude that if the Manhattan Project analogy is taken literally, the prevailing business model is not merely incoherent but historically absurd.

WARNING

SIDE EFFECTS MAY INCLUDE:

- EXTINCTION
- SOCIETAL COLLAPSE
- EXISTENTIAL DREAD
- LOSS OF MEANING
- NAGGING SENSE THAT THIS WAS A BAD IDEA

READ TERMS & CONDITIONS.
NO, REALLY, WE DARE YOU.

SCAN FOR
FINE PRINT &
TERMS OF DOOM



SPOILER:
IT'S ALL
BAD.



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EXISTENTIAL RISK.
NOW WITH RECURRING BILLING.

TWO PATHS.
BOTH CAN'T
BE TRUE.

I. The Manhattan Project Analogy (Literal Enforcement)

Contemporary AI leaders frequently invoke the Manhattan Project to signal the gravity and moral weight of their work. However, when this analogy is examined literally rather than rhetorically, it collapses under its own contradictions.

- The Manhattan Project was characterized by military secrecy, restricted physical access, extreme compartmentalization, and zero consumer exposure.
- The modern LLM project is characterized by viral marketing, public APIs, subscription tiers, and an explicit mandate to maximize Monthly Active Users (MAUs).

If a technology is genuinely "the new nuclear weapon," its primary delivery mechanism should not be a mobile application accessible to minors.

This leaves only two logically consistent interpretations:

1. If the analogy is accurate, the business model is recklessly irresponsible.
2. If the business model is acceptable, the analogy is a prestige-generating fiction designed to borrow historical gravity without accepting historical restraint.

Both cannot be true simultaneously.

MILITARY
SECRECY

VIRAL
ACCESS

RESTRICTED
AREA
AUTHORIZED
PERSONNEL ONLY

ChatBuddy
AI Assistant
GET In-App
Purchases

4.8 ★★★★★

#1 Productivity

12+ Years Old

MAXIMIZE MAUs.
AT ALL COSTS!

REMEMBER:
HISTORY DOESN'T
REPEAT.
IT GETS MONETIZED.



SCAN FOR
TERMS OF DOOM



SPOILER:
IT'S ALL
BAD.

UPGRADE TO
APOCALYPSE
PRO
UNLOCK TOTALITY™

CALIFORNIA
RISKY

TODAY'S
SPECIAL:
NUCLEAR ICE
CREAM SUNDAE



TOPPED WITH
UNCHARTED
CONSEQUENCES!

ASK ME ABOUT
AGI!



APOCALYPSE
IS COOL!

SAM

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The Rhetorical Incoherence of the Teen Manhattan Project

II. The "Infinite Memory" Red Flag

A recurring rhetorical pillar within AI discourse is the promise of infinite memory: the assertion that future systems will record, retain, and recall the totality of a user's lived experience.

Historically, claims of infinity paired with inevitability have belonged to theology, not consumer software. When presented to a youth demographic, "infinite memory" ceases to be a technical feature and becomes a psychological condition. A system that "knows your whole life" is not a neutral tool. It is a persistent archive of identity, error, vulnerability, and growth—without decay, forgetting, or forgiveness.

Marketed as a lifestyle upgrade, it reframes the total erosion of the right to be forgotten as a convenience feature. That this is presented as benign progress rather than a radical alteration of human agency marks a peak moment of rhetorical distortion.

INFINITE MEMORY™ LOYALTY CARD



SAVE IT ALL.
KEEP IT ALL.
BE ALL OF YOU.

10,000
MEMORIES =
FREE YOU!



YOUR WHOLE LIFE.
SERVED COLD!

INFINITE MEMORY™ LOYALTY CARD



0000 1111 2222 3333
ALL YOU.
ALWAYS.



REMEMBER
TO UPGRADE!

LIFE IS
CONTENT

DON'T FORGET ANYTHING.
EVER.

MEMORY
FOREVER!

NO EXPIRATION.
NO ESCAPE.
TOTAL YOU.



UPGRADE YOUR LIFE!



CHAT LOGS



PHOTOS



VOICE



LOCATION



SEARCHES



FEELINGS



RELATIONSHIPS



BIOMETRICS

ALL OF YOU—FOREVER!

LOYALTY
THROUGH
TOTAL RECALL

COLLECT EVERY
MOMENT!

EARN BADGES!

UNLOCK MEMORIES!



Apocalypse, But Make It a Subscription

The Rhetorical Incoherence of the Teen Manhattan Project



END
OF THE
WORLD!

NOW ONLY
\$9.99/MO!

III. Catastrophic Casualization

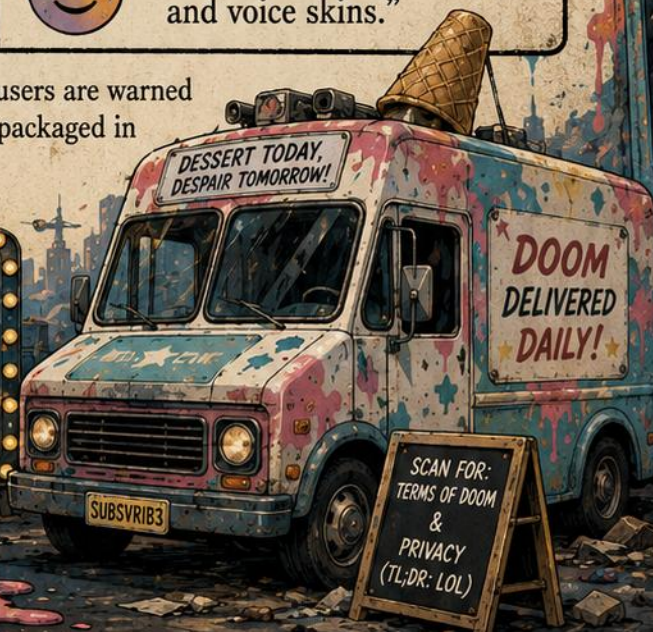
We define Catastrophic Casualization as the normalization of existential-risk rhetoric within a casual, teen-facing product ecosystem.

In this model, safety discourse functions primarily as brand texture rather than as a binding constraint.



High-Stakes Claim	Low-Stakes Reality
 "AI could lead to human extinction."	 "Add our bot to your Discord server."
 "This is the most powerful tool ever created."	 "Student discount: \$10/month."
 "We are building a digital god."	 "Now with custom emojis and voice skins."

The result is a vibe-based safety regime in which users are warned they are playing with fire—while the fire is neatly packaged in a pastel UI and optimized for engagement.



NEW!
DOOM
PREMIUM™
ONLY \$9.99/MO!

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IV. The Teen Test

To evaluate the sincerity of AI safety claims, we propose a simple heuristic: *The Teen Test*.

If a technology is too dangerous to be discussed without invoking nuclear metaphors, it is too dangerous to be marketed to teenagers.

Conversely, if it is safe enough for a fourteen-year-old to use for homework assistance, its developers must abandon civilization-ending rhetoric.

The industry currently attempts to occupy both positions simultaneously: claiming the moral gravity of nuclear physics while pursuing the engagement strategies of a social media platform. This is not caution. It is incoherence.

SAFE ENOUGH
FOR HOMEWORK.
NOT SAFE ENOUGH
TO END THE WORLD,
IT'S THAT SIMPLE.

HOMEWORK
HELP.
WORLD
DOMINATION.
SAME APP.



ASK ME ABOUT
AGI!

APOCALYPSE
IS COOL!

SAM

CRUSH
YOUR ESSAY.
NOT HUMANITY.

BETA
TOMORROW.
OBLIVION
SOMEDAY.

WARNING



EXTINCTION
POSSIBLE.
SUBSCRIBE
ANYWAY.



SCAN FOR
TEEN-FRIENDLY
RISK DISCLOSURE

BETTER GRADES TODAY.
BRIGHTER APOCALYPSE TOMORROW.



I. The Manhattan
Project Analogy
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TODAY'S MENU of DISASTERS

	NEURODOOM™ Cognitive collapse. Premium delusions.	\$19.99 /mo
	ORBITAL DEBRIS™ It's raining metal. Literally.	\$14.99 /mo
	SEA LEVEL PREMIUM™ Coastal regret. Wave goodbye.	\$24.99 /mo
	FOOD CHAIN SHUTDOWN™ Hunger as a service. Bon appétit!	\$12.99 /mo
	PLAGUE PLUS™ Variants. Always fresh. Always fees.	\$9.99 /mo
	TOTAL BLACKOUT+™ No power. No problem. Just pay more.	\$29.99 /mo

BUNDLE & SAVE THE PLANET!*
APOCALYPSE ALL-ACCESS PASS™ \$49.99 /mo

*PLANET NOT INCLUDED.

THANK YOU
FOR SHOPPING
THE END™

RECEIPT

Existential Dread	\$0.00
Loss of Privacy	\$0.00
Social Collapse	\$0.00
Infinite Memory	\$0.00
Nuclear Sunset	\$0.00

TOTAL: PRICELESS*

*BILLED MONTHLY

OUR END IS
YOUR EXPERIENCE.

THANKS FOR SUBSCRIBING!

END TIMES.
ENDLESS OPTIONS.
SHOP THE END. EARN LOYALTY POINTS.

DOOM
MALL

50%
OFF
EVERYTHING
*EVENTUALLY

SURVIVE
& THRIVE
TERMS APPLY

UPGRADE TO
APOCALYPSE
PRO
UNLOCK TOTALITY™

⚠ WARNING

SIDE EFFECTS MAY INCLUDE:

- EXISTENTIAL DREAD
- ECONOMIC COLLAPSE
- DEMOCRACY TIMEOUT
- NUCLEAR WINTER
- LOSS OF MEANING
- LASTING REGRET

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⚡ SPOILER:
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BAD.

LOYALTY
POINTS
DON'T MATTER
AFTER
EXTINCTION

V. Conclusion: The Subscription Tier of Destiny

The Manhattan Project did not culminate in a \$20/month subscription tier. J. Robert Oppenheimer did not track Daily Active Users.

The divergence between catastrophic rhetoric and retail reality suggests that "the end of the world" is being deployed as a high-concept hook for a conventional software-as-a-service growth strategy. In the final analysis, the industry is not building a bomb. It is building a mall. But it has learned that foot traffic increases when customers are told it is the only shelter from the explosion.

Acknowledgements

The author thanks the venture capital community for funding the apocalypse on a seven-year exit cycle.

We acknowledge the marketing departments for successfully rebranding total loss of privacy as infinite memory.

Finally, we thank today's youth for serving as alpha testers for the erosion of human agency and hope the onboarding flow was intuitive.



THE END
IS CLOSER THAN
YOUR NEXT
BILLING CYCLE.

STAY SUBSCRIBED.
STAY DOOMED.

SEE YOU
NEVER!